Yaqar

יָקָר

yaqar — precious, costly; rare. Strong's H3368 (adjective); the verb is H3365.

Yaqar is a word you would hear in a yard where stone is sold. Solomon's foundations were laid with it — costly stones, cut to measure. Isaiah's cornerstone is one. The Queen of Sheba arrived with gold, spices, and stones the word describes. Proverbs says wisdom is worth more than any of them.

It is not a warm word. It is what something fetches.

It also means scarce. Before Samuel hears anything, the narrator tells you the word of the LORD was *yaqar* in those days — rare, and not often seen.

Price and scarcity sit inside the one word. A thing is dear because there is not much of it.

The Psalms use it nine times, and it is worth seeing what they put a price on.

A ransom for a life, which no one can afford. A man in his pomp, twice in the same psalm, who will not remain. The splendour of the pastures, which goes up like smoke.

Expensive, and going.

Twice the word is used of something that is not going. God's *hesed*, in Psalm 36. God's thoughts, in Psalm 139. Both times a man is doing the valuing, and both times what he values is not his.

Ask who holds the glass, and the answer is nearly always a person.

In the Psalms, once it is a king. Psalm 72 gives him a poor man's blood and says it is precious in his sight – which is what a good king is for, and is the psalm's way of saying he has his priorities right.

And then God takes the glass up himself. *You are precious in my eyes, and honored, and I love you.* Isaiah is speaking to people who have been carried off and who have every reason to think they were cheap. God prices them.

> *Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints.*

The jeweller's word, used of a grave. Not that the dying is good. That it is not cheap, and not unnoticed, and not written off.

Peter Gill flew P2-UIF. He and Molly came to Papua New Guinea in the mid-eighties, and they became our friends – our children were of an age and played together. I flew with him often.

In 1992 the aircraft went down in the highlands. Peter was killed, and everyone on board with him.

On his headstone at Bomana we put Psalm 116:15.

Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints.

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.